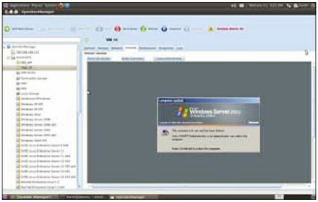

Figure 8: VM console window

Figure 9: Import VM wizard

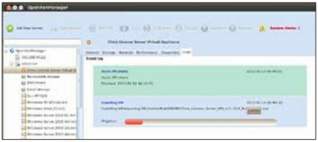

Figure 10: Importing the appliance

OpenXenManager doesn't warn you about activating the XenServer with the free licence. You have to do it manually within 30 days; till then you can enjoy the platinum version's features. To get your activation file for a free licence, go to *http://deliver.citrix.com/go/citrix/xenserver_activation* and register with your valid email ID, as the licence file will be sent through e-mail. Download the *license.xslic* from your email ID and copy it inside the Citrix XenServer's */etc/xensource/* using a removable drive. Then remove the file extension *.xslic* and reboot the XenServer. OpenXenManager supports licence activation using the Citrix licence server appliance and it doesn't support the free licence activation.

But once activated with the free licence, it displays the dialogue box for attaching the licence file, which is a little buggy though. Your home lab is now almost ready to rumble. OpenXenManager provides you loads of information about your hypervisor hosts and running VMs.

Create your first VM

With this release, XenServer has increased support for guest OSs including Ubuntu 10.04, Debian 6, Oracle EL 6, SUSE EL 10 SP4, and experimental support for Solaris 10 and Ubuntu 10.10. Before hopping on to the virtualisation bandwagon, you have to create some storage repositories. XenServer supports all kinds of storage options.

First create an ISO repository for storing all ISOs, or improvise the CD/DVD drive of Xen Hypervisor. Create new storage for all your virtual machines if you have a NAS or iSCSI, although you can use a locally attached HDD on your hypervisor to store virtual machines—it won't impact the performance of your home lab. If you want to make your home lab near perfect, you can use OpenFiler to create a NAS and use its iSCSI capability. With two such machines and iSCSI or NAS at your disposal, you can also try out XenMotion, a Live Migration feature offered by XenServer. To create a new VM, click the New VM button on OpenXenManager.

A wizard will appear with myriad options, ranging from Windows to Linux templates, and will guide you through configuring the installation media (the ISO repo, XenServer or DVD drive), HomeServer (storing VM locally), CPU and memory, storage and networking, before you can hit *Finish*.

The moment you do so, you will be directed to the VM Console screen, where the VM will boot and the setting up starts.

After setting up the OS, you can either use OpenXenManager Console or RDP to access the VM you just created. You can also import a pre-built Xen compatible appliance (.xva or Xen Virtual Appliance) using the import VM wizard as shown in Figure 9.

This wizard is straightforward and asks you for the home server (local storage), storage and network.

After hitting Finish in the import wizard, OpenXenManager will start the import of Xen Virtual Appliance.

With this kind of home lab set-up, you can unleash the raw power of your desktop machine and utilise its full potential. A home lab can also help you nurture your virtualisation, storage and networking skills. Hope you liked this crazy ride. END

References

[1] *www.citrix.com/xenserver*
[2] *http://support.citrix.com*

By: Harsh Gupta

The author is a Linux enthusiast with over five years of experience in open source, network and storage administration. Learning new technologies is his favourite hobby.